ETON Advanced French Grammar: Specialists

EW 9

49. **THE PRESENT PARTICIPLE is formed by adding -ANT to the stem of the *nous* form of the present tense:**

lançons : **lançant** — *mangeons* : **mangeant** - *finissons* : **finissant**

There are only 3 IRREGULARS - *être* : **étant** — *avoir* : **ayant** - *savoir* : **sachant**

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50. **EN is the ONLY preposition that can be used with the Present Participle**

— This means 1 of 4 things : **by** doing something **while** doing something
on doing something **in** doing something

— Sometimes there is no by/while/in/on in English, but *EN* + PRESENT PARTICIPLE is still used when the action recorded by the -ING verb is **simultaneous** with the action recorded by the main verb which comes before it:

e.g. - "Look out!" he shouted, opening the door

"Attention!" a-t-il crié en ouvrant la porte

- He thanked her getting out of the lift

Il l'a remerciée en sortant de l'ascenseur

If the preposition before the English -ing construction is anything other than by/while/in/on (eg before -ing) you will probably be using an infinitive after the French preposition. (See below)

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51. **The Present participle is used WITHOUT *en***

i) **where the -ING verb gives a reason for the action of the main verb**

e.g. Knowing that she liked cheese, I bought some Brie

Sachant qu'elle aimait le fromage, j'ai acheté du Brie

ii) **where the action recorded by the -ING verb does not happen at the same time** as the action recorded by the main verb, but rather records the following action

e.g. She went in, closing the door behind her

Elle est entrée, fermant la porte derrière elle

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52. **Note the following idiomatic use of EN + PRESENT PARTICIPLE with verbs of motion**

— to run in : *entrer en courant*
— to run off : *partir en courant*
— to run out : *sortir en courant* -
— to run upstairs : *monter en courant*
— to run downstairs : *descendre en courant*

He ran downstairs : *Il est descendu en courant* **OR** *il a descendu l'escalier en courant*

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53. **After verbs of perception (seeing etc) what appears to be a present participle in English will be an infinitive in French or you may use a clause using the imperfect tense:**

He saw her walking down the street : *Il l'a vue marcher dans la rue*
or *Il l'a vue qui marchait dans la rue*

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54. **IN NONE OF THE ABOVE USES OF THE PRESENT PARTICIPLE DOES THE PARTICIPLE EVER AGREE IN NUMBER OR GENDER.**

You should also complete the pre-test exercises as part of your EW

eg She ran outside : *Elle est sortie en courant*
She came in smiling : *Elle est entrée en souriant*

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55. AFTER DOING SOMETHING (*après avoir / être* + past participle)

a) for verbs that use *avoir* as an auxiliary, take *après avoir* and add the past participle

e.g. **After seeing** the film, we went home at midnight
Après avoir vu le film, nous sommes rentrés à minuit

If there is a direct object pronoun used with the *après avoir* construction the past participle will agree with the direct object in the same way as it does in compound tenses

After listening to them we put the records away
Après les avoir écoutés nous avons rangé les disques

b) **for verbs that use *être* as an auxiliary** take **après être** and add the past participle. This must be made to AGREE WITH THE SUBJECT of the following clause.

e.g. After coming so far, she refused to wait
Après être venue si loin, elle a refusé d'attendre

c) **for reflexive verbs** (take one of **après m'être** / **après t'être** / **après s'être** / **après nous être** / **après vous être** or **après s'être** and add the past participle. Make sure you use the

appropriate reflexive pronoun for the subject of the sentence. It is important that you check the rules for agreement of the participle on pages 10 and 11.

e.g. After going to bed early, she couldn't get to sleep
Après s'être couchée de bonne heure, elle n'a pas pu s'endormir

After washing our hands, we went upstairs
Après nous être lavé les mains, nous sommes montés

BUT After wondering if she would come they rested
Après s'être demandé si elle viendrait ils se sont reposés

NB *après avoir* & *après être* + PAST PARTICIPLE can ONLY be used where the subject of the *après avoir/après être* verb is also the subject of the following verb.

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56. BEFORE DOING SOMETHING : *avant de* + INFINITIVE

With reflexive verbs, be careful about choosing the right reflexive pronoun (**me, te, se, nous, vous, se**) in front of the infinitive.

e.g. Before putting on my gloves, I had to go and fetch them upstairs
Avant de mettre mes gants, j'ai dû aller les chercher en haut

Before going to bed, I always have a glass of milk
Avant de me coucher, je bois toujours un verre de lait

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57. **IN ORDER TO DO SOMETHING** : *pour* + INFINITIVE / *afin de* + INFINITIVE

— In order to be on time : *Pour être à l'heure*
— In order not to miss the train : *Pour ne pas manquer le train*
— In order to do it : *Pour le faire*

58. **WITHOUT DOING SOMETHING** : *sans* + INFINITIVE

— I went in without paying : *Je suis entré sans payer*
— He went out without looking at me: *Il est sorti sans me regarder*

59. **Only 2 verbs in French can be followed by *PAR* + INFINITIVE**

to begin by doing something : *commencer par faire qch*
to end up doing something : *finir par faire qch*

— If you begin by smoking 1 cigarette a day, you end up smoking 20
Si on commence par fumer une cigarette par jour, on finit par en fumer 20

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